

ING OF THE END

STRONG PUBLIC RESENTMENT to the imposition of Emergency, disquiet in the military over recent developments, creeping Talibanisation and rising US pressure may force Musharraf out of power sooner rather than later.

■ By Hasan Zaidi in Karachi

Those whom the gods wish to destroy, they first make mad." A popular columnist for Pakistan's respected newspaper *Dawn* often quotes this line from Greek playwright Euripides to explain the follies of Pakistani establishments. It would be difficult to find a more apt sum-up of the popular reaction to the Army Chief General Pervez Musharraf's coup against the system he set in place himself as President. With one fell stroke on November 3, Musharraf swept aside not only the Constitution, but also hobbled the independent judicial system and rolled back years of glasnost in

the electronic media, the latter one of his most touted achievements in power.

Citing "threats to the existence of Pakistan itself" brought on by rising extremism and "a judiciary working at cross-purposes with the government", he declared a state of Emergency and promulgated a new Provisional Constitutional Order under which judges had to seek a fresh oath. Simultaneously, new decrees were issued providing for stringent curbs on the media, including forbidding "the projection of anything...that defames, and brings into ridicule or disrepute, the head of state, or members of the armed forces or executive, judicial or legislative organs of the state."

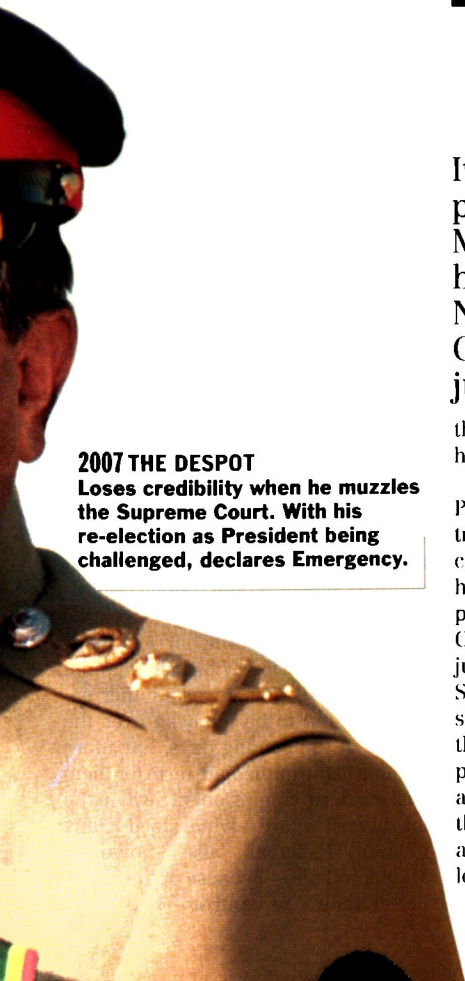
All privately-owned television news

channels, including foreign ones such as BBC and CNN were blacked out even before the declaration of Emergency. Thus it fell to the print media—also under threat of punitive action—to inform Pakistanis that most of the judges of the Supreme Court and many of the judges of the provincial high courts—including two high court chief justices—had refused to take oath under the new Constitutional Order and that, in fact, seven judges of the Supreme Court, including the chief justice, had even declared it unconstitutional before they were put under house arrest.

While some sitting ministers described the declaration as "Emergency Plus", most people were under no illusion as to the nature of the new set-up.

2007 THE DESPOT

Loses credibility when he muzzles the Supreme Court. With his re-election as President being challenged, declares Emergency.



Pervez Musharraf: AP Photo/Tony Stone Worldwide
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